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3. Knowing God (Step 1: Adopt a correct view of God)

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3. Knowing God (Step 1: Adopt a correct view of God)

If we want to stop committing a habitual sin, we should first look at what we are doing and then develop strategies for changing our behavior, right? Wrong. The first step should be to start at the other end—not with ourselves but with God. That is why step one in breaking a sinful habit is to *adopt a correct view* of God. The more fully we understand the nature of God, the better we will understand how we should live in this world.

In general, we make our decisions on a rational basis. We try to understand the facts and then make a reasonable choice based on what we know (or what we think we know) as well as on what we feel. This is true in all areas of life. For example:

- If we believe that hard work leads to success, then we are more likely to be diligent on the job.
- If we believe that for a democracy to work best it requires the participation of all its citizens, then we will probably vote.
- If we believe that rich relationships are among the greatest blessings of life, then we will be more inclined to invest time in our friendships.

In short, our *convictions* influence our *behavior*. For this reason, it is important that we have the right convictions in the first place. And since our convictions about God are above our convictions in all other categories, it is supremely important that we have the right convictions about Him.

We may get our ideas about God from many sources—pop culture, religious teaching in our childhood, the example of human authority figures, conversations with our friends, the latest “spiritual” book on the bestseller list, and so on. Sadly, these sources often provide flawed concepts of God and skewed attitudes about Him. The result is that we act upon mistaken notions of who God is and how He behaves toward us.

One of the most tragic trends in our churches today is the faulty way believers view God. It accounts in large measure for the fact that so many Christians are living with sin in their lives. A. W. Tozer wrote in his book *The Knowledge of the Holy*:

The low view of God entertained almost universally among Christians is the cause of a hundred lesser evils everywhere among us....

*It is impossible to keep our moral practices sound and our inward attitudes right while our idea of God is erroneous or inadequate. If we would bring back spiritual power to our lives, we must begin to think of God more nearly as He is.*¹

In fact, everything about our lives—our attitudes, motives, desires, actions, and even our words—may be influenced, at least indirectly, by our view of God. An improving view of God, then, means we may be energized to recognize our sin and to deal with it in a godly way. Consider these examples:

- Someone who is learning that God is a Father who promises to provide for His children (Matthew 6:32–33) may worry less about getting enough of this world’s goods.
- Someone who has discovered that “God is not a God of disorder but of peace” (1 Corinthians 14:33) might reconsider her irresponsible, disorderly way of life.
- Someone who is beginning to sense that God is not distant but always near to him (Psalm 139:7) might hesitate before indulging in his “hidden” sin of sexually fantasizing about women.

Such examples show that theology (literally, “the study of God”) is a most practical exercise. We do not all have to be experts in doctrine, but we do have to have a sound idea of who God is if we are going to act as we should. So, how do we go about knowing God?

God’s Self-Portrait

As we begin our attempts to know God better, we should admit one fact: God is beyond our ability to fully comprehend Him. “My thoughts are nothing like your thoughts, says the LORD. And My ways are far beyond anything you could imagine” (Isaiah 55:8). In the end, God remains a marvelous mystery. Praise God for His incomprehensible greatness!

Yet at the same time, this God is a God who wants to be known. He reveals to us everything about Himself that we really need to know. And He bids us come looking for Him. An honest search for Him is one that He readily rewards with disclosure of Himself. He promises, “If you look for me in earnest, you will find me when you seek me” (Jeremiah 29:13).

The apostle Paul, in establishing the guilt of sinful people who did not have the advantages of being a part of the Jewish community, explained that God has placed clues about Himself both inside each person and all around us.

The wrath of God is being revealed from heaven against all the godlessness and wickedness of men who suppress the truth by their wickedness, since what may be known about God is plain to them, because God has made it plain to them. For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities—His eternal power and divine nature—have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that men are without excuse. —Romans 1:18-20 niv

Instinctive knowledge of God placed in our hearts: that is the witness of our conscience. God's invisible qualities are displayed in the earth and sky and all He has made: that is the witness of nature.

But conscience and nature can only tell us so much about God. They reveal generalities and not specifics. To live life in a fully God-pleasing manner, we need more detailed information about who God is and what He wants of us.

The Bible is our most comprehensive guide to the nature of God. It was “inspired by God” (2 Timothy 3:16), and so it preserves God's own witness to who He is. It is His self-portrait. Above any other source, then, we need to find out what God says about Himself in the Bible. If we will take the time to study what Scripture says, we can arrive at a picture of God that certainly is not complete but that is more than adequate for our needs.

Moreover, we can trust that the God who appears in the pages of Scripture is the same God we are seeking to know better today. “I am the Lord, and I do not change,” He testifies (Malachi 3:6). What He says specifically about Himself in Scripture, and what He demonstrates about Himself through His actions recorded in Bible stories, reveals the real God.

We need to be willing to open up our minds to the biblical picture of God. If we ask the Holy Spirit to reveal truth to us from the Bible, He will do so. And as we study Scripture, its picture of God will crowd out our old, mistaken view of God and establish a truer picture in its place.

The Purification Process

The ways in which people have gone wrong in their opinions about their Creator are almost as numerous as the human race itself. The diversity of religious beliefs in the world bears witness to how we can be misled about God.

First of all, of course, it is important to believe that God exists. “Anyone who wants to come to Him must believe that there is a God” (Hebrews 11:6). Certainly atheism has been responsible for some of the most dreadful abuses in history, as people have gone astray through the rejection of God. The psalmist was right:

*Only fools say in their hearts,
“There is no God.” —Psalm 14:1*

But of course, most people in our land do believe in God. In fact, only 8 percent of Americans describe themselves as atheists or agnostics.¹ Naturally, though, this does not mean that 92 percent of us have an accurate or adequate view of who God is. Misunderstanding about God’s nature, even when it comes to the basics, is widespread, despite the prevalent belief in the existence of God.

One key reason why so many misunderstand God today is the current do-it-yourself approach to religion. At one time, Christianity was the starting point for the theology of most Americans (whether or not they actually had saving faith in Christ). Today, though, many put together pieces of Christianity, New Age spirituality, and whatever else appeals to them, then endorse the resulting hodgepodge as their theological doctrine. Consequently, while they may be enthusiastic about “God,” the God they have in mind bears little resemblance to the God of the Bible.

If you are reading this book, most likely you are not an atheist. However, there is a good chance that your image of God has been distorted in some significant ways with additions from worldly sources. So prepare to go through a purification process as you filter out mistaken notions about God that you have acquired.

Having flawed convictions about God is not necessarily a sin in itself—your education in this area may have been at fault. But do not let yourself become comfortable with unexamined convictions. Get to know God better in His self-portrait, the Bible, and start erasing those parts of your image of Him that do not fit

what He says about Himself. Then fill in the picture with true ideas about God's nature. You will benefit from knowing more about both who God is and how He acts toward you.

Transformation of your heart, soul, and will occurs as you choose to discover and believe the truth about God.

Who God Is

Some years ago I (Bill) wrote a book about the attributes of God, called *God: Discover His Character*.² I got the idea for the book as a result of being interviewed by Dr. James Montgomery Boice on the *Bible Hour* radio program. One of the first questions Dr. Boice asked was "What is the most important truth to teach any follower of Christ?"

No one had ever asked that question of me before, so for a moment, I was speechless. Finally, I answered, "The attributes of God." Later I thought about my answer (prompted, I believe, by the Holy Spirit) and realized that it really was true. Human problems are commonly due, at least in part, to a faulty or inadequate understanding of God.

This is why I would urge you to learn more about the attributes of God. These attributes are primary qualities or characteristics belonging to God.

1. *God is all-powerful.* "Lord, there is no one like You! For You are great, and Your name is full of power." —Jeremiah 10:6
2. *God is ever-present.* "I can never escape from Your Spirit! I can never get away from Your presence!" —Psalm 139:7
3. *God is all-knowing.* "How great is our Lord! His understanding is beyond comprehension!" —Psalm 147:5
4. *God is sovereign.* "Everything in the heavens and on earth is Yours, O Lord, and this is Your kingdom." —1 Chronicles 29:11
5. *God is holy.* "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord Almighty! The whole earth is filled with His glory!" —Isaiah 6:3
6. *God is truthful.* "It is impossible for God to lie." —Hebrews 6:18
7. *God is righteous.* "Everything He does is just and fair. He is a faithful God who does no wrong; how just and upright He is!" —Deuteronomy 32:4

8. *God is just.* “Mighty king, lover of justice, you have established fairness.” —Psalm 99:4
9. *God is loving.* “See how very much our heavenly Father loves us, for He allows us to be called His children, and we really are!” —1 John 3:1
10. *God is merciful.* “God is so rich in mercy, and He loved us so very much, that even while we were dead because of our sins, He gave us life when He raised Christ from the dead.” —Ephesians 2:4-5
11. *God is faithful.* “Your faithfulness extends to every generation, as enduring as the earth you created.” —Psalm 119:90
12. *God is unchanging.* “He never changes or casts shifting shadows.”
—James 1:17

For you as someone who is seeking to overcome a habitual sin, these attributes of God all relate to the issue of trust. Can you trust God to help you with your sin problem? In what ways is He trustworthy? Only when you know God will you be able to trust Him with all your heart.

“How do I know I can trust God?” you might ask. Well, how do you determine if you can trust people when you have a need?

For example, if you needed a ride home from a party late at night and someone said, “I’ll take you,” you would quickly assess whether you could or could not trust that person. First, you might consider that person’s ability. *Does he have a car and a driver’s license?* Next, you might look at that person’s integrity. Does he keep his promises? And finally, you might think about his commitment to you. *Does he care enough to want to help?*

God is able (He is all-powerful, ever-present, all-knowing, and sovereign). God has integrity (He is holy, truthful, righteous, and just). And God is committed to you (He is loving, merciful, faithful, and unchanging). You can trust Him as you make choices day by day.

How God Acts Toward Us

Learning about the nature and attributes of God, as revealed by the Bible, is far from being a mere academic exercise. We discover in the process a God who cares about us, who is intimately involved in our lives, and who wants to help us heal from our sin problems.

Let's consider the twelve attributes of God listed above in terms of how they relate to our problems with habitual sin. Each attribute should be an encouragement to us.

1. Because God is all-powerful, He is stronger than the hold that sin has over us.
2. Because God is ever-present, He is always with us in our struggles against temptation.
3. Because God all-knowing, we can go to Him with all our questions and concerns about becoming holy.
4. Because God is sovereign, we can submit to His will for our ethical actions.
5. Because God is holy, He offers the model of morality we strive to copy.
6. Because God is truthful, we can believe what He says about sin and holiness and live accordingly.
7. Because God is righteous, He provides the standards we seek to live up to.
8. Because God is just, He always treat us fairly, even when we disappoint Him.
9. Because God is loving, He is unconditionally committed to our spiritual well-being.
0. Because God is merciful, He forgives us of our sins when we sincerely confess them.
1. Because God is faithful, we can trust Him to always keep His promises to help and to forgive.
2. Because God is unchanging, His commitment to our spiritual health is fixed and dependable.

What a God we serve! His every quality is suited to drawing us nearer to Him and to helping us become the kind of people He wants us to be.

Furthermore, the fact that God is a Trinity—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together—teaches us that God values fellowship. God enjoys fellowship among the three Persons that make up the unity of the Godhead, and He enjoys fellowship with us, His most beloved creatures. And so the three divine Persons work together to solve our sin problem: The Father established the standards of justice. The Son sacrificed Himself to earn our forgiveness. And the Spirit comes alongside us to aid us in our attempts at living holy lives.

Isn't this a God you want to know better? We promise that as you get to know Him more fully, He will begin to change your thoughts and feelings in ways that will make you more ready to part with your habitual sin and to embrace holiness.

How good it is to know God as He really is! A revolution in our view of God can start a revolution in our behavior, but adopting a correct view of God is only the beginning. We move from there to evaluating other ideas and feelings that may underlie our sinful behavior.

One person who is starting that journey is a former military officer named Eldon.

God and Holiness

A retired lieutenant colonel in the Air Force, Eldon prided himself on his strength of will and self-reliance. That is why it hit him so hard when he could not beat the habit of taking painkillers.

It all started innocently enough when his doctor prescribed pain medication following back surgery. Later, even though the back pain was gone, Eldon felt out of sorts once the pill bottle was empty. His thoughts kept returning to the pills and the way they had made him feel. So he found a black-market supplier and bought the pills illegally.

For a while, Eldon told himself that he needed the pills for medicinal reasons. But before long his natural honesty kicked in and he woke up to what he was really doing. He realized that he was taking the pills simply because he *wanted* to, not because he *had* to.

Eldon defined his problem as an addiction. But at the same time, he realized that what he was doing was a crime and a sin. As a longtime Christian, Eldon knew he was to blame before God. He felt a shame unlike any he had known before.

True to his character, Eldon tried to break the habit by going cold turkey. And more than once he thought he had succeeded just by “gutting it out,” as he described it. But then—somehow—he always found himself calling his supplier once again.

Then one time, unbeknownst to Eldon, his supplier was under surveillance by a plainclothes police officer when Eldon drove up for a buy. The humiliated colonel was arrested with a bag of pills in his automobile’s glove box.

As part of his sentencing, Eldon was ordered to see a counselor. He chose a Christian counselor who, among other things, delved into Eldon’s attitudes toward God.

It turned out that Eldon viewed God as distant, rather like his father had been. God judged, but God did not help. This was not so bad when Eldon was behaving properly, but such a conception of God plunged Eldon into guilt and fear when his considerable willpower was not enough, as with the pills.

“Has it ever occurred to you that God aches when He sees you returning to your drug habit?” asked the counselor one time.

“Oh, no,” replied Eldon without hesitation. “He must be angry with me. How could He be otherwise? I was doing something wrong.”

On another occasion, the counselor inquired, “How do you seek God’s help with your problem?”

“I don’t. It’s not His place to reach down and get involved in my petty problems. That’s my job.”

The counselor urged Eldon to work with one of the pastors at his church to learn more about God as He is portrayed in the Bible. The counselor said goodbye to Eldon at the end of that session in the hope that he would learn that God is merciful as well as righteous, involved in our lives as well as reigning above us.

How good it is to know God as He really is! A revolution in our view of God can start a revolution in our behavior, making us more holy like the holy God. But adopting a correct view of God is only the beginning. We move from there to evaluating other ideas and feelings that may underlie our sinful behavior.

Life Reflection

1. What words would you use to describe the qualities you see in God? What do you think may be the connection between your view of God and your sin?
2. Do you trust God to help you with your sin problem? Why or why not?
3. What do you need to do to learn more about what God is really like?

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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